FREE BROCHURE

Wanted and Unwanted Touch

Clear, literal rules for telling OK touch from touch that is not OK, with feelings-check pictures, scripts and a write-in page.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children, young people and adults, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA · Adults

Easy read

Touch can be wanted. Touch can be unwanted. I can say stop. I can tell a grown-up I trust.

How to use this resource

- Read the rules on page 2 together. Learn them as rules, one at a time.
- Use the feelings-check pictures on page 3 to practise noticing how touch feels.
- Fill in the 'Who I can tell' page on page 6 with the child or young person, then keep it somewhere safe.
- Adults: read the notes on page 7 about responding if a child tells you something.

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Version 1.0 · wanted-and-unwanted-touch

We all have the right to feel safe

My body is mine. I decide about touch. Nothing is so awful that we can't talk about it with someone we trust.



I have the right to feel safe.



My body is mine.



I can say stop.



I can tell a grown-up I trust.

Wanted touch

Wanted touch is touch I choose and I like. I can change my mind at any time. Examples: a hug from Mum that I want, a high-five, a pat on the back that I like, holding hands when I choose to.

Unwanted touch: when is touch not OK?

These are literal rules. They always apply, whoever the person is.



Rule 1

Touch is not OK if I said stop. If I say stop, the touch must stop.

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Rule 2

Touch is not OK on my private parts. The parts under my underwear are private.

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Rule 3

Touch is not OK if someone says keep it a secret. I can always tell.

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Notes for adults: the exception for care and medical touch

- Private parts are only touched for care or medical reasons: for example, a nurse or doctor with a parent or trusted carer there, who explains first. A parent or carer may help with washing or toileting when a child needs it, explained and agreed.
- Even then, the child should be told what will happen, and can ask to stop. Use your intimate care plan. Two staff are usually present in schools.
- If someone touches a child's private parts and it is not for care or medical reasons, or without explanation, or in secret, it is not OK.

Feelings check: how does this touch feel?

My body can tell me. Look at the pictures. Which one is like me? Some people feel more than one feeling. Some people do not notice for a while. That is fine.



Happy and calm

I like it. I feel safe. It is OK.

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Not sure

I do not know how I feel. I can say wait. I can ask a grown-up.

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Worried or tight

My tummy feels tight. I do not like it. I can say stop.

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Heart beats fast

I feel hot or shaky. I can say stop and get away.

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Sad or flat

I feel sad or numb. I can tell someone I trust.

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Cross

I feel cross or want to push away. I can say stop.

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My body signals

When I do not like touch, my body feels: _____

The first thing I notice is: _____

Something that helps me feel calm is: _____

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Secrets and surprises

A **surprise** is a nice thing that other people will find out soon, like a birthday present. A **secret** can make me feel worried, and someone may say I must never tell.

Surprise: OK

- A birthday present.
- A surprise party.
- Makes me feel happy and excited.
- Will be told soon.

Secret: tell

- Makes me feel worried or sick.
- Someone touches me and says do not tell.
- Someone says never tell anyone.
- I can always tell a trusted adult.

A happy surprise is OK to keep for a short time.

A secret that worries me is not OK to keep.

I will not get into trouble for telling.

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Scripts: how to say stop and how to tell

Practise these out loud. Use your own words if you like. You can also use a card, a talker, or write it down.

Saying stop

'Stop. I do not like that.'

Going away

'No. I am going now.' Then walk away to a safe place or a safe person.

Telling an adult right away

'Someone touched me and I did not like it. I need to tell you.'

When it is hard to say

'I have something hard to say. Can I write it down?'

If the first adult does not listen

'I told you something important. Please listen. I will tell someone else.' Then keep telling until someone listens.

About a secret

'Someone asked me to keep a secret and it worries me. I am telling you.'

- Say stop.
- Go away to a safe place.
- Tell a grown-up I trust.
- Keep telling until someone listens.

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Who I can tell

Fill this in with a trusted adult. Think about people at home, at school and in the community. Keep it somewhere safe and easy to find.

My trusted adults

At home, I can tell: _____

At school, I can tell: _____

Another adult I trust: _____

If I cannot tell them, I can phone or text: _____

My five-finger network (one person on each finger)

Thumb: _____

Pointer finger: _____

Middle finger: _____

Ring finger: _____

Little finger: _____

Free help any time

- Childline (under 18): phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or childline.ie. Free, 24 hours.
- Text About It: text HELLO to 50808. Free.
- Emergency: 112 or 999.

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Notes for adults: if a child tells you

How to respond

- **Stay calm.** Your face and voice matter. Take a slow breath.
- **Listen and believe.** Let them tell it their way. Use words, writing, drawing or pictures. Do not push for details.
- **Say thank you for telling me.** 'It is not your fault. You did the right thing.'
- **Do not promise secrecy.** Say: 'I have to tell someone whose job it is to keep you safe.'
- **Do not ask leading questions** and do not investigate. Only ask open questions: 'Can you tell me more?'
- **Write down what they said**, in their own words, with the date and time.
- **Report the same day.** In school, tell the Designated Liaison Person (DLP). Otherwise contact Tusla. If a child is in danger now, call 112 or 999.

Children First

Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children (2017) sets out what adults should do if they are concerned about a child. The Child Protection Procedures for Schools (2023) set out what schools must do. Do not wait for proof. A reasonable concern is enough to report. You do not have to be certain.

Teaching tips

- Teach the rules before a problem, at a calm time, and repeat them often.
- Some autistic children have difficulty reading danger, pleasing others, or saying no. Practise scripts and use visuals.
- Some children may tell by behaviour, not words: new fear, regression, withdrawal. Stay curious and kind, and ask for advice.
- Teach older young people about consent and about the law, including online images. See our 'Introduction to Consent' book.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Safety and protection*; Stay Safe programme (primary child-abuse prevention).
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality**, and Strand 4 **Emotional Wellbeing**.
- Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children (2017); Child Protection Procedures for Schools (2023).

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

An Garda Síochána

Contact your local Garda station, or 112 or 999 in an emergency. Garda Confidential Line: 1800 666 111.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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